

IS OLD REALLY GOLD?

PLANNED OBSOLESCENCE AND COMPLEXITY...

We've all experienced this in some form or the other. If it's not a firsthand experience, then it certainly is something you've heard your parents or grandparents say at some point in life. And of course every generation thinks theirs was the best, but we're not talking just about that inherent bias that we all have... we're talking about actually verifiable evidence of cars from the 1960s or 1950s still running, some of them despite being abused and run on kerosene! Some families have a fridge that is older than you, others have toasters from the 1970s. Clothes, radios, and everything that remotely passed for technology also seemed to just be better designed from back in the day. But was it?

FOOL'S GOLD?

The Old is Gold feeling might have some truth to it in terms of how older things seemed to just last forever and not break down as often, but you also have to wonder if they're really gold? When talking about the first ever mobile phones that we bought, the team was comparing models and riding the nostalgia train. The oldest members of the team even reminisced back to the "good old days" of pagers and phones with single line LCD displays only capable of showing black text the way cheap calculators do now!

Our Ed (Raaabo) was recounting how his old Ericsson GH-337 once jumped out of his shirt pocket while he was running to catch a bus. It hit the side of the bus, went flying across the road, the battery came flying off and was promptly ridden over by a cycle,

the phone and sim thankfully avoiding traffic. Aghast, he ran to pick up the pieces of his precious phone, fearing the worst. He connected the battery back to the phone, held down the "No" button to power it on, and voila, it worked. No real damage other than a few scratches on the body of the phone.

Would he be willing to use that phone now instead of his expensive Android phone? Heck no! So are all those old devices really "gold" or are they just good memories of simpler times? That's what we hope to find out.



"Woman's Friend" washing machine from 1890.
Our apologies for the blatant sexism of the time...

PLANNED OBSOLESCENCE

It was an American industrial engineer called Clifford Brooks Stevens (often referred to only as Brooks Stevens) who first coined the term "Planned Obsolescence" in the 1950s. He defined it as the artificial shortening of the life of a product by manufacturers. To be clear, it wasn't his idea, as people often mistake him for inventing the idea itself. He merely noticed the trend in the manufacturing industry and gave it a name, so don't hate him for it.

It makes no economic sense to make a product that will last forever. When a market was brand new, and there were almost no adopters of a technology or product, it made sense to create products that were of the highest possible quality.

After all, you wanted the first washing machines to work well, to last long, and to need almost no repairs. This is because you were selling the concept of a washing machine to households that were used to washing clothes by hand.

We're choosing a washing machine because it is one of the most common devices in households across the globe, second only to refrigerators.

The humble fridge, however, had much less of a battle to fight, because something that could keep food from spoiling was a no-brainer. With a fridge you could cook food in larger quantities than your family could consume in a single meal. The concept of leftovers was born,

and vegetables could be made to last longer, as could milk, eggs, and other staples in diets. There was no one who was "against refrigerators", merely those who could afford it and those who couldn't. That's why we chose the washing machine as our example.

Before washing machines, housewives, maids and laundry services would need to wash clothes by hand. Water had to be gathered and carried to a place it could be heated, and this hot soapy water was precious! Laundry needed to be prepared and